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NAVIGATING BY LAMPLIGHT
Sushil Modi (centre) inaugurates a function at the Bihar Chamber of Commerce in Patna

BIHAR

RETURN OF THE OTHER MODI

By Amitabh Srivastava

The BJP in Bihar was on a high in March 2022—with three Vikassheel Insaan Party MLAs joining it, its tally in the state assembly went up to 77, making it the single largest party for the first time. April, however, was a crueller month: first, at the legislative council elections, the ruling NDA alliance did much worse than before. Then, in mid-April, came the humiliation at the Bochaha assembly bypoll. That led, on April 21, to the stings from within that hurt many BJP leaders in Bihar—in a series of tweets, Rajya Sabha MP and former deputy chief minister Sushil Kumar Modi publicly reflected on why the twin setbacks deserve "deeper introspection".

Modi's open hint about a possible lack of synergy between his party and ruling alliance partner Janata Dal (United) was a sharp rap for the state BJP. The April 16 bypoll result had seen the RJD (Rashtriya Janata Dal)'s Amar Paswan crushing the BJP candidate, Baby Kumari, by a margin of over 36,500 votes. After the lacklustre show in polls for 24 legislative council seats—the BJP won six seats, the JD(U) five, but the alliance lost 10 seats it held, and the RJD, winning six, emerged as the big gainer—the gloom had deepened.

This is when Sushil Modi's tweets recalled how the NDA, working "in complete coordination", had swept the 2019 Lok Sabha poll in Bihar, winning 39 of 40 seats. His harking back to a phase of good understanding clearly implied a lack of that quality now. Modi also suggested a possible alienation of Extremely Backward Classes (EBC) and a section of dominant caste voters. With the Lok Sabha poll a mere two years away, not exactly a happy thought.

Unlike in 2019, the NDA is now a house divided in Bihar, with a steely edge colouring the air and politicians often openly snapping at each other in a borderline acerbic tone. Take the exchanges between BJP state chief Sanjay Jaiswal and JD(U) parliamentary board chairman Upendra Kushwaha. Or the time when, last month, JD(U) national president Rajiv Ranjan Singh declared that Nitish Kumar was chief minister on the "strength of people" and not on anyone's *kripa* (mercy). It was seen as a rebuff to some BJP leaders demanding a CM from their party.

BY RECALLING THE SYNERGY IN THE BIHAR NDA IN HIS TIME, SUSHIL MODI IS SENDING A SIGNAL

Clearly, the smooth camaraderie in evidence when Modi was in charge of the state BJP is long gone—and that forms the crux of his call for "introspection". In the backdrop of a resurgent RJD under Tejashwi Yadav, can the party afford to let the current batch of BJP leaders bicker on with the JD(U)? "Will the BJP leadership keep promoting confrontational leaders in the name of grooming new ones in Bihar and risk the party's 2024 prospects, or will they bring back trusted leaders like Modi for smoother alliance politics?" asks a BJP leader. Modi was picked as deputy CM in November 2005, when Nitish started his first full term as CM, and retained the post in all JD(U)-BJP governments. Though BJP hardliners blamed him for playing second fiddle to Nitish, many credit him for associating the party with the idea of 'good governance'. The sharing of positive vibes with Nitish was central to that—even recently, he stressed that Nitish would remain CM till 2025.

After the 2020 assembly election, however, the BJP replaced its top leadership with new, untested leaders. Modi was made a Rajya Sabha MP. Two other senior leaders, Nand Kishore Yadav and Prem Kumar, seven- and eight-time MLAs respectively, were not allowed to join the new cabinet. Going by Modi's recent moves, it seems the 70-year-old is staking claim to the state party leadership just when the Union MoS for home Nityanand Rai—BJP MP from Bihar's Ujiarpur—is positioning himself as a saffron face for the 2025 assembly poll. Many think his timing is impeccable—there are indications that the BJP may drop some "non-performing" ministers in the upcoming cabinet rejig in Bihar. ■